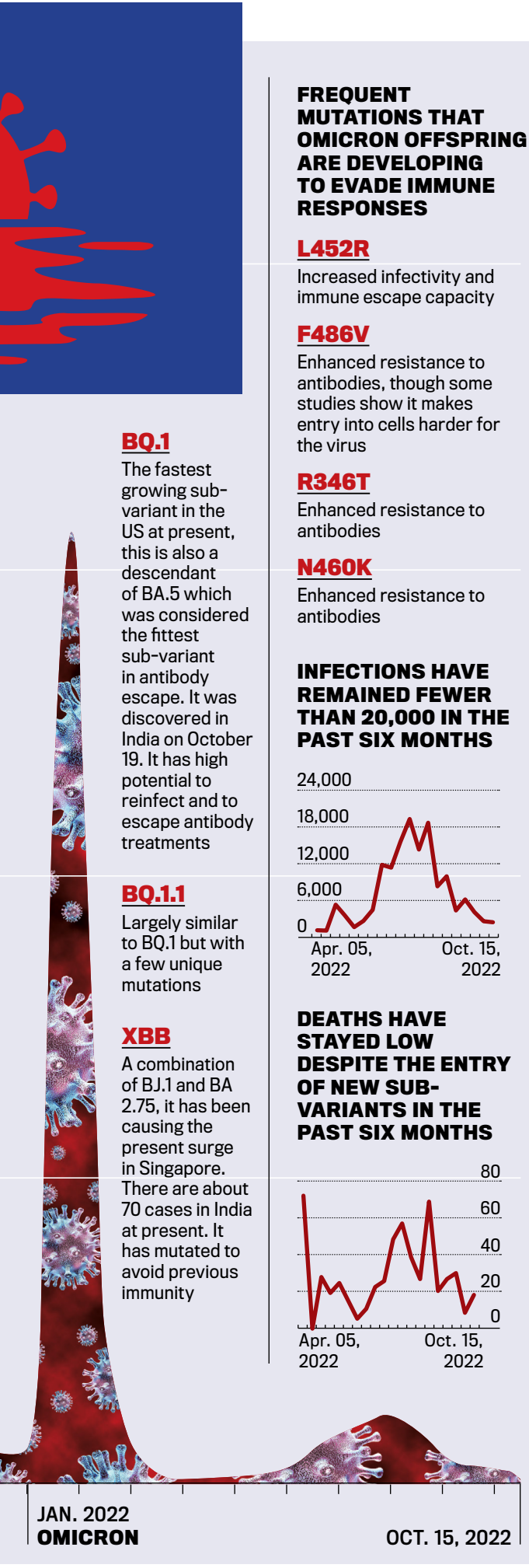


Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

you won't get severe disease if you have acquired immunity through appropriate vaccination and/ or by natural exposure to the virus. You cannot say that Covid will not claim lives. Even influenza still claims lives—between 300,000 and 600,000 people die every year from it. We don't call influenza a pandemic any more because we are now familiar with it and influenza cases have become seasonal—they multiply before the onset of the winter season. Influenza cases have continued to cause serious pandemic in the past."

Virologist Dr Shahid Jameel, too, is reluctant to hazard a definite stance that the pandemic is over. "From a technical view, the pandemic is on, as there is disease in multiple nations and WHO has not declared it to be over," he says. But he does concede that "from a social view, nobody is worrying about it because the impact on health is minimal."

The virus is still very much around. Reincarnated in sub-variant BF.7 (a branch of the original Omicron parent) and recombinant strain XBB (combining the BA.2.75 and BJ.1 strains), it has caused a 14 per cent rise in cases in the UK, 33 per cent in France and a fresh XBB wave in Singapore that could see 15,000 new cases a day. China, where the virus originated, also saw a surge in cases caused by the BF.7 variant in the first week of October, with 3,092 new cases on October 8, though they came down to 952 new cases in 10 days. The country has been following a zero-Covid policy, enforcing strict lockdowns wherever there is an outbreak, the latest being in Zhengzhou district, following six new cases there. There was a slight uptick in infections in India too. The country saw a 30 per cent jump in new infections on October 13, which has since declined. On October 16, only 2,401 new cases were recorded.

But Dr Kang sees a difference in the Indian and western experiences, on account of two factors. "India has had 90 per cent infections and 90 per cent vaccination. Plus, our population structure has only 10 per cent above the age of 60 (the age after which immunity has been known to decline sharply). In countries where there are more elderly, or where populations do not have previously-gained natural or vaccine immunity, there will be surges."

Over 70 per cent of the world is now vaccinated. The vaccination programme in India, too, is going strong. Over 300,000 shots were given on October 18, a majority of them precaution doses. The natural or vaccine-acquired immunity has forced Omicron, the dominant variant of concern (VoC), to mutate (see *Viral Trajectory*) in order to evade human antibodies and survive. The virus itself has not become weaker, and therefore causing less severe disease. "It is wrong to say the virus is causing milder disease," says Dr Mishra. "Rather, our immune systems are primed to prevent severe illness. After we get infected, our antibodies kick in. In the meantime, the virus replicates and moves to a new host." So far, the virus hasn't been able to mutate to